

AG2120 H25 International Administration and Policy

Course coordinator: Kristen Kao

The course content and overall structure remained broadly consistent with previous years. The principal change was in staffing as Kristen Kao assumed responsibility for a larger share of the lectures as well as an additional seminar, after Magnus Lundgren had to withdraw from the course owing to other commitments.

The first half of the course focused on issues of international administration and policy in relation to armed conflict and post-conflict societies. In this section, Kristen Kao took over the lecture series on armed conflict and conflict resolution, delivering it in a more condensed format. She also further developed the lecture introduced last year on the measurement of social science concepts, with the aim of better preparing students for assignments requiring them to locate publicly available data and use it to evaluate international interventions. The expansion of this lecture appears to have been beneficial in encouraging students to engage more seriously with methodological questions, to understand the basic logic of experimental design, and to develop a foundational ability to read and interpret quantitative outputs for use in their theses and future professional work. This is particularly important given that data analysis is increasingly relevant to the kinds of careers many of our students pursue in public and international sectors. Kao also continued to teach the lecture series on transitional justice and reconciliation.

The second half of the course followed the same general structure as in the previous year, addressing themes of aid, development, corruption, institutions, and democratization, with particular emphasis on how international actors and interventions may contribute to desirable outcomes. In response to feedback from prior years that the course had felt somewhat fragmented because of the number of different instructors involved, teaching this year was concentrated among just three instructors: Kristen Kao, Agnes Cornell, and Marcia Grimes.

As in previous years, students were required to complete two shorter seminar papers, one oral presentation, one group presentation, and one longer research paper. These components were retained in full despite the fact that the course coordinator volunteered to relinquish eight teaching hours from the course allocation. The reduction was absorbed through fewer grading hours for instructors rather than through any cut to course content.

The course offered students a choice among four seminar assignments, from which they selected one in the first half of the course and one in the second. In response to student feedback from last year requesting more preparation time, the assignments were posted considerably earlier. Students were informed at the outset that, if extended preparation time was important to them, they should take this into account when selecting their assignments. The intention behind offering a choice of assignments was to allow students to select tasks that aligned with areas in which they felt they needed additional training and/or that would be valuable for their future academic or professional work. Although this may not always have been apparent to students, the assignments were also deliberately designed to support thesis preparation by developing skills in analytical thinking, data collection and organization, literature review, and the construction of coherent arguments about research design, evidence, and limitations.

The course also included a student conference, during which students presented background research in groups. As last year, the conference was scheduled before the Christmas break. The purpose of the group work was to deepen students' understanding of the broader issues, international interventions, local politics, and historical context surrounding their country cases, thereby providing a stronger foundation for their final papers. Abstracts for the final papers were likewise due before the Christmas break and were discussed with Kristen Kao and Marcia Grimes.

About 45% of the students filled out the survey this year (20 of 44 students). Students' overall evaluations of the course were somewhat less positive than in previous years. Fifty percent of respondents rated the course as "very good" or "rather good," while 35 percent assessed it as "neither good nor bad." Three students rated the course as "rather bad" or "very bad." Although this represents a decline compared with earlier years, other evaluation items were substantially stronger. Seventy percent of students rated the teachers overall as "rather good" or "very good," 80 percent gave these ratings to the course literature, and 75 percent did so for the usefulness of the seminar assignments.

Some students commented that the reading load remained too heavy. In fact, the reading list had already been reduced for this year in response to the same concern raised previously, but I will review it again with this issue in mind when planning for next year. Students also noted that too much material was sometimes being compressed into lectures and that seminars felt rushed. This year, we introduced designated student discussants for each paper presentation at the seminar to help them develop 'on the spot' speaking skills. This innovation does not appear to have been especially well received, and it is true that, given the number of students and the limited seminar time available, discussions can become constrained. We will therefore work next year to streamline the seminar format and consider how to create more space for discussion, potentially including the removal of designated student discussants.

There were also comments expressing a desire for more time to discuss the final paper. At the same time, the course offered two three-hour supervision sessions devoted to final papers—one before and one after the Christmas break—yet only a small number of students attended these sessions. There was also an opportunity for a short final-paper Q&A during my lecture just before the break. This suggests that not all available support resources are being fully utilized and that, once the opportunities have passed, they may not remain in the memory of students who did not take advantage of them.

Finally, make-up assignment sessions were conducted over Zoom this year in an effort to reduce the likelihood of inappropriate AI use. Previously, the make-up task had consisted of critically assessing two other students' assignments or papers, depending on the relevant component being made up; however, this had become a format that was too easily completed with AI assistance. We have not yet conducted a full debrief on how well the revised format functioned in practice. Overall, 8 students received a VG, 18 received a G, and 18 are incompletes officially. Of the incompletes, 1 is completed but has not yet been registered as such, 5 failed and 5 never submitted the final paper, 3 missed other aspects of the course and are still making them up, and 4 are re-registered students from earlier years. This is a high number of incompletes. It indicates that perhaps the workload is too much for this course, although it has not changed in recent years. It could also somewhat reflect the effects of AI, which students are perhaps relying upon and then failing assignments since AI is not actually able to do the work. It could also reflect the shift to Zoom make-up exams, which makes students not make them up as easily or quickly as they did previously (the previous assignment was to critically assess other students' papers). We should discuss this.

Looking ahead, there is a promising opportunity for the course to collaborate with the UN International Organization for Migration. They have expressed interest in involving students in the production of reports based on their own program data, particularly in the areas of youth, peace and security, and gender, peace and security. This could provide students with unique and valuable opportunities, including interviews with staff and partner organizations, access to organizational data, informational lectures by practitioners, feedback from IOM teams, and the possibility of contributing to a publishable report. Advice on how best to structure such a collaboration within the course would be very welcome! I believe these reports would be best if they could replace the final paper and perhaps to address complaints that the workload felt too heavy and disjointed, we could make the assignments more cumulative, building up to these final reports rather than focusing on wholly different topics. There is a trade-off, of course, between breadth (right now students have to focus on numerous different interventions and country cases) and depth (potentially having students digging deeper into and understanding

one case more fully).